

ASHRIS CHOUDHURY

INDRA GITA



WHAT INDRA TAUGHT KRISHNA

A Sample Reading Pack

Indragita

What Indra Taught Krishna

A Philosophical Dialogue

Drawn from the Rigveda, the Mahabharata, the Upanishads, and the Bhagavad Gita

This pack contains the complete framing material of the book, three of its twelve adhyayas, and the closing afterword. The chapters chosen, **The Descent, On Karma and the Instant Rebirth**, and **The Question**, give the editor the opening of the dialogue, its single clearest philosophical statement, and the parting bargain between Krishna and Indra with which the book closes.

The full manuscript runs to twelve adhyayas and roughly forty thousand words. The full designed editions (light, dark, and print-ready) are available alongside this sample.

By Ashris Choudhury

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

PREFACE	Preface
INTRODUCTION	Introduction
ADHYAYA 1	The Descent
ADHYAYA 3	The Fire on Your Own Soil
ADHYAYA 5	On Karma and the Instant Rebirth
ADHYAYA 12	The Question
AFTERWORD	On the Society Indra Imagines
GLOSSARY	Glossary

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PREFACE

The Indian tradition has always renewed itself through dialogue.

The Gita is a dialogue. The Upanishads are dialogues. Yajnavalkya and Gargi, Krishna and Arjuna, Ashtavakra and Janaka, the Buddha and his questioners, Adi Shankara and Mandana Mishra. Every age that mattered to us produced its own conversation, in its own voice, and added a room to the house we still live in.

This book is one such conversation, set at the close of the Dvapara Yuga, between Indra, king of the Devas, and Krishna, in the last hours before Jara's arrow. It is offered in the same spirit our rishis offered theirs: not to overturn what came before, but to keep the inheritance alive by handling it again.

Two figures sit in the foreground of our philosophical memory. One is the Krishna of the Bhagavad Gita, the teacher of *nishkama karma*, non-attachment, and the unchanging Atman. The other, less remembered, is the Indra of the Rigveda. Long before the Puranic tradition diminished him, Indra was the king who acted, who wanted, who chose, who fought, who lost, and who returned. Vedic hymns sang his name as the lord of *vajra* and *soma*, the breaker of obstacles, the one in whom the world delighted because he delighted in the world.

Somewhere along the way, that Indra grew quiet in our imagination. The strand of the tradition he represents, an ethic of agency, of owned desire, of full-hearted engagement with the world, was overshadowed by the literature of renunciation. It did not disappear. It survived in the Karma Kanda of the Vedas, in the householder ideals of the

Dharmashastras, in the lives of the kings, builders, poets, and devotees who shaped this civilization. But it lost its voice in the philosophical foreground.

This book is an attempt to give that voice back to it.

I write neither as a sannyasi nor as a scholar in the conventional sense. I work with patterns, with primary texts read closely, with the comparative discipline that the Vedic tradition itself prized. I have spent years on the Rigveda, the Mahabharata, the Upanishads, and the long arc of Indian philosophical thought. What follows is what I found when I let the older Indra speak for himself: not a rejection of Krishna's teaching, but a complement to it, a second door for the householder, the builder, the artist, the parent, the warrior, who reads the Gita and feels that something in their own life has not yet been named.

In the dialogue that follows, Indra and Krishna do not part as enemies. They part as brothers who serve different children. The peace Krishna offers is real, and it has held generations. The fire Indra offers is also real, and it has built them. Both belong to us.

For the reader who comes to this book carrying the Gita: nothing here asks you to set it down. For the reader who has felt that the Gita was not quite addressed to them: this book may be the older cousin you did not know you had.

The fire is old. Older than the words we use to describe it. This is one more attempt to remember it well.

— *Ashris Choudhury, 2026*

INTRODUCTION

The Setting

It is the end of the Dvapara Yuga. The Mahabharata war has been fought and won. Eighteen akshauhinis of soldiers lie dead. The Pandavas rule a kingdom of ghosts.

And now the Yadavas, Krishna's own clan, have destroyed themselves at Prabhasa, drunk on wine, killing each other with iron clubs that grew from a sage's curse. The city of Dvaraka is sinking into the sea.

Krishna sits alone at the edge of the forest where it meets the ocean. He is waiting for a hunter named Jara, whose arrow will strike his foot and end his avatar. He has seen this death. He has allowed it.

This is where Indra comes.

Not in thunder. Not with the host of Maruts. He walks out of the tree line like a man approaching another man. Only his eyes hold the storm.

Why Indra?

In the Bhagavata Purana, Krishna and Indra are adversaries. The young Krishna convinces the cowherds of Vrindavan to stop worshipping Indra and instead worship Govardhana Hill. Indra, enraged, sends storms to destroy them. Krishna lifts the mountain on

his finger and shelters his people for seven days. Indra submits. He is “humbled.”

But what if we read this episode differently?

What if Indra’s submission was a long patience? What if he watched the arc of how Krishna’s philosophy would later be received, and waited for the right hour to come back into the conversation as an equal, not an adversary?

Indra, unlike mortal philosophers, is not bound by time’s arrow. The Devas, in the older texts, see what was, what is, and what will be as a single landscape. What Indra speaks of in this dialogue, peoples not yet born, empires not yet risen, he sees not as prophecy but as memory of a future already complete. To him, the Tang and the Cholas are as present as the Yadavas dying on this beach. This is his authority: not argument, but witness.

And the Indra-spirit, the principle of full-hearted engagement with the world, never left this civilization. It lived in Chandragupta, the Vratya who built an empire from nothing. It lived in Rajendra Chola, whose ships carried the dharma across the sea. It lived in Karna, who refused to be defined by his birth. These are Indra’s heirs, whether they ever called on his name or not.

That moment of return is now. At the end of Krishna’s life. When the long fruit of his teaching is finally visible, and a complementary voice can be heard without competition.

The Philosophical Stakes

The Bhagavad Gita teaches:

- **Nishkama karma:** Action without attachment to results
- **Anasakti:** Non-attachment to outcomes

- **Samatva:** Equanimity in pleasure and pain, victory and defeat
- **Atman as unchanging:** The self is eternal, beyond the body's drama
- **World as maya:** The material world is illusion; transcendence is the goal

The Indragita does not refute these. It draws out a parallel set of teachings, equally rooted in the older Vedic literature, for the reader whose temperament asks for a different door:

- **Sincere desire:** Own what you want, clearly and without shame
- **Karma as mechanism:** The past constrains but does not determine; identity can be rewritten instantly
- **The nobility of taking sides:** Choosing is what makes you real
- **Fierce attachment:** Love that risks loss is the only love worth having
- **The world as arena:** Real, consequential, worth engaging fully

The Indragita does not set out to refute the Gita. It opens a second door inside the same house, one for the reader whose path is the path of engagement, of building, of fierce love, of consequential choice. Both doors open onto the same Vedic ground.

A Note on Indra

Indra in the Rigveda is not the diminished figure of the later Puranas. He is the king of the Devas, the slayer of Vritra, the one who releases the waters, drinks the soma, and delights in the world. He wants things. He takes sides. He wins, loses, and returns. More hymns of the Rigveda are addressed to him than to any other deity. The very first hymn of his great cycle opens with the line that the entire Vedic age took as a declaration of what mattered:

इन्द्रस्य नु वीर्याणि प्र वोचं यानि चकार प्रथमानि वज्री ।
अहन्न अहिम् अन्व अपस् ततर्द प्र वक्षणा अभिनत् पर्वतानाम् ॥

*indrasya nu vīryāṇi pra vocaṇ yāni cakāra prathamāni vajrī ।
ahann ahim anv apas tatarda pra vakṣaṇā abhinat parvatānām । ।*

*"I will declare the manly deeds of Indra, the first that he achieved, the
Thunder-wielder. He slew the Dragon, then disclosed the waters, and cleft
the channels of the mountain torrents."*

— Rigveda 1.32.1

The Puranic tradition softened him. He grew jealous, insecure, threatened by the austerities of mortals. This served a theological need of its own time: as the Trimurti (Brahma, Vishnu, Shiva) rose to the centre of devotional life, the older Vedic deities receded into the background.

In this text, I return to the Rigvedic Indra and let him speak in the voice the early hymns gave him. He stands here as a philosophical archetype: the god who acts, desires, risks, and remains.

ADHYAYA 1:

The Descent

At the edge of Prabhasa, where the forest meets the sea, Krishna sat alone. The Yadavas had slain each other. The city of Dvaraka was sinking. The age was turning.

The sea was the color of old copper. Somewhere behind him, smoke still rose from Dvaraka.

He had known it would end this way. He had seen it, spoken it, allowed it.

The hunter's arrow would come soon. He was waiting for it the way one waits for a guest who is late but certain.

Instead, Indra came.

Not in thunder. Not with the host of Maruts. He came as a man comes to another man, walking out of the tree line, his footsteps making sound on the earth, his shadow falling in the ordinary way. Only his eyes held the storm.

INDRA: You taught the world to let go. And now you sit here, letting go. I want to know if it feels the way you promised it would.

KRISHNA: *(not looking up)* Careful, Shakra. The last god who came to test me lost his armies and his pride. You lost them to a child with a mountain on his finger. Surely you remember.

INDRA: I came to ask a question. I'll only stay if you can bear to answer it honestly.

KRISHNA: *(slight smile)* Honesty. You think I've been dishonest?

INDRA: I think you've been so clever that you've forgotten what honesty costs. You told Arjuna that the wise grieve neither for the living nor the dead. You told him the soul is eternal, the body is clothes, death is a change of garments.

KRISHNA: This is true.

INDRA: And did Arjuna fight better for believing it? Or did he fight the way a man fights when he's been told it doesn't matter?

KRISHNA: *(steel in his voice)* He fought. He won. The righteous sit on their thrones. Is that not what wars are for?

INDRA: The war ended. Yes. I was there when Bhishma fell. I watched Arjuna's face. Do you know what I saw?

KRISHNA: Tell me.

INDRA: Relief. Not victory. Not grief. Not even hatred fulfilled. Relief that it was over.

Krishna's jaw tightened. The wind shifted, carrying the smell of salt and ash.

INDRA: That he could stop performing the thing you'd asked him to perform.

KRISHNA: You misread him. Arjuna carried the Gandiva. He was my instrument and my friend. You, who have never carried anything but your own ambition, cannot read such a man.

INDRA: I have killed more enemies than you have hairs on your body, Vasudeva. I know what a warrior's face looks like when he wins. That was not it.

KRISHNA: What would you have had me teach him? To slaughter his grandfather with joy? To laugh while cutting down his teachers?

INDRA: I would have had you teach him to *want* his victory. To own it. To say: I am killing Bhishma because I choose to, because the throne matters to me, because my brothers matter to me, because I refuse to live as a beggar when I was born a prince.

KRISHNA: And the sin of killing?

INDRA: Let him carry it! Let him feel its weight! A man who kills and feels nothing is not liberated, he is broken. You taught him to pre-forgive himself by pretending he wasn't really the one doing it. That Time was the killer. That the selves were already dead.

KRISHNA: (*quieter*) It was a mercy.

INDRA: It was a trick. And tricks produce tricksters. I have watched your pundits, Keshava. They speak of detachment while scheming for temple gold. They quote your "action without fruit" while angling for the king's ear. The gap between word and deed has grown so familiar that no one notices it.

KRISHNA: You would judge my teaching by its worst students?

INDRA: When every student misreads a teaching the same way, the teaching is at fault. Tell me: in the ages since Kurukshetra, what has your philosophy made? Saints? Yes, rare, like diamonds. And hypocrites, common, like dust. The hypocrites cloak themselves in the saints' words, and your civilization slowly, beautifully, sinks into sophisticated helplessness.

KRISHNA: *(rising, facing him)* And your path, Shakra? To feel every death, every failure, every wound without the armor of perspective? How many of your devotees have you driven to madness with that weight? I taught men to carry the unbearable by making it lighter. You would crush them with truth.

INDRA: I would make them strong enough to be crushed and rise again.

KRISHNA: Strong. You speak of strength. You who lost your worshippers to a cowherd's rebellion. You whose throne shakes whenever a mortal's austerities grow too great. Teach me about strength.

INDRA: *(sitting down across from him)* I will. Because I have done what you have never done. I have wanted things, and failed to get them, and remained Indra. I did not console myself by saying I never really wanted them. I did not say desire is the enemy. I lost, and I wanted, and I kept wanting, and I tried again.

And here is the thing you miss, Govinda: the wanting was not ego. Ego would have said "I am Indra, I cannot lose." But I did lose. And I did not shatter, because my sense of self was not built on being invincible. It was built on being the one who keeps choosing. The one who authors his life, even when the story turns against him.

That is the teaching.

KRISHNA: *(almost amused)* You have not changed, Shakra. Even now, at the end, you come to argue.

INDRA: *(a ghost of a smile)* Would you have me come to weep? We both know that is not my way.

KRISHNA: No. I suppose not.

A long silence. The waves spoke their ancient language. The smoke from Dvaraka drifted across the horizon.

KRISHNA: *(slowly sitting back down)* Then speak. The arrow is not yet here. I will listen. Not because I agree, but because even the old must sometimes hear new questions.

INDRA: Not new questions, Govinda. The oldest questions. The ones you buried when you chose safety over fire.

Krishna looked at him for a long moment. Then, slowly, he nodded toward the empty space beside him.

KRISHNA: Sit. And tell me what you have seen.

*Adhyaya 2 is omitted in this sample pack.
It develops the conversation through **The Wound of Time**.*

The sample resumes with Adhyaya 3.

ADHYAYA 3:

The Fire on Your Own Soil

INDRA: I will not speak yet of the Greeks. I will not speak of the Persians. I will not speak of any people you can dismiss as mlecchas. I will speak of your own soil. Of the fire that burned here before your philosophy extinguished it.

KRISHNA: You claim my own tradition supports you?

INDRA: I claim your own tradition *is* me. Before the philosophers came. Before the hierarchies calcified. Before wanting became sin.

The Rigveda Remembers

INDRA: Let me quote to you your own holiest text.

Your Rigveda, the oldest hymns, the ones your priests claim to revere above all others, says this:

कामस्तदग्रे समवर्तताधि मनसो रेतः प्रथमं यदासीत् ।
सतो बन्धुमसति निरविन्दन् हृदि प्रतीष्या कवयो मनीषा ॥

*kāmas tad agre samavartatādhi manaso retah prathamam yad āsit ।
sato bandhum asati nir avindan hṛdi pratīṣyā kavayo manīṣā ।।*

"Thereafter rose Desire in the beginning, Desire, the primal seed and germ of Spirit. Sages who searched with their heart's thought discovered the existent's kinship in the non-existent."

— Rigveda 10.129.4 (Nasadiya Sukta)

KRISHNA: The Nasadiya Sukta speaks of cosmic origins, not individual craving.

INDRA: It speaks of *Kāma*. Desire. Want. Your oldest text says that desire is the origin of *everything*.

Before the gods. Before dharma. Before your philosophy of detachment. There was Wanting. And from Wanting, all else arose.

When did you start teaching that the First Seed was poison?

KRISHNA: (*measured*) The sages distinguished between cosmic desire and personal craving. The creative impulse of Brahman is not the same as personal craving.

INDRA: The sages made no such distinction. That came later. That came when philosophers grew embarrassed by their ancestors' hungers.

And they said something else, Govinda. They said:

को अद्धा वेद क इह प्र वोचत् कुत आजाता कुत इयं विसृष्टिः ।
अर्वाङ् देवा अस्य विसर्जनेनाथा को वेद यत आबभूव ॥
इयं विसृष्टिर्यत आबभूव यदि वा दधे यदि वा न ।
यो अस्याध्यक्षः परमे व्योमन् सो अङ्ग वेद यदि वा न वेद ॥

*ko addhā veda ka iha pra vocat kuta ājātā kuta iyaṃ visṛṣṭiḥ ।
arvāṅ devā asya visarjanenāthā ko veda yata ābabhūva । ।*

*iyaṃ viśṛṣṭir yata ābabhūva yadi vā dadhe yadi vā na |
yo asyādhyakṣaḥ parame vyoman so aṅga veda yadi vā na veda | |*

*“Who verily knows and who can here declare it? The Gods are later than
this world’s production. Who knows then whence it first came into being?
Perhaps he knows not.”*

— Rigveda 10.129.6-7

Indra’s voice dropped.

“Perhaps he knows not.” Your Vedas *questioned*. They did not claim certainty. They did not say “All is Brahman and here is the manual.” They said: we do not know, and that is part of the glory. When did your children stop questioning and start reciting?

What Your Ancestors Actually Prayed For

INDRA: And what did your ancestors pray for, Govinda? What did they ask of me when the soma was fresh and the fire was high?

They prayed:

*सं गोमदिन्द्र वाजवदस्मे पृथु श्रवो बृहत् ।
विश्वायुर्धेह्यक्षितम् ॥*

*saṃ gomad indra vājavad asme prthu śravo brhat |
viśvāyur dhehy akṣitam | |*

*“Give, Indra, wide and lofty fame, wealthy in cattle and in strength, lasting
our life-time, failing not.”*

— Rigveda 1.9.7

They asked for wealth. They asked for victory. They asked for fame. They asked for sons.

They were not ashamed of wanting. They did not say “I offer this soma but I am not attached to whether you grant my prayer.” They *wanted*, and they said so.

KRISHNA: The Vedas are one stage of development. Later teachings refined ...

INDRA: Later teachings *retreated*. Later teachings were embarrassed by the hunger of the ancestors. Later teachings said: those old hymns were for lesser souls. We have evolved past wanting.

But the evolution was not upward, Govinda. It was backward. Into the cave. Into the lotus position. Into the comfortable certainty that nothing matters.

The Hypocrisy of Brahman

INDRA: And here is the strangest irony of your teaching.

You say “All is Brahman.” The atman in the Chandala is the same as the atman in the Brahmin. In the eyes of the ultimate, there is no high, no low, no pure, no impure.

And yet, and *yet*, your children still will not eat together.

KRISHNA: (*stiffening*) That is the corruption of the teaching, not the teaching itself.

INDRA: A philosophy that is misread identically by millions is not being misread. It is being read correctly.

You gave them “All is Brahman” with one breath and “your karma placed you here” with the next. The first dissolves hierarchy. The second sanctifies it.

Your teaching did not dissolve caste. It made caste *sacred*. “It is his karma to be born low.” That is crueler than any foreign chain, because it teaches the chained that their chains are justice.

KRISHNA: *(with sudden force)* And you think I do not know this? You think I have not seen what priests make of philosophy? I was born in a prison, Shakra. My family was hunted. I know what power does with teachings.

INDRA: *(a beat)* Then why did you give them such perfect tools for hiding?

Silence. The tide pulled back, dragging shells across stone.

KRISHNA: *(quieter)* Because the alternative was chaos. Men need order. They need to believe their suffering has meaning. Without the frame ...

INDRA: Without the frame, they might have built a different frame. One that did not require them to see their children’s suffering as deserved.

On Skin and Spirit

INDRA: And here is another irony your children will live.

They will worship the skin of their ancestors while spitting on the spirit of their ancestors.

KRISHNA: Speak plainly.

INDRA: They will become obsessed with fairness. With light skin. With creams and lotions and the shame of being dark. They will spend fortunes trying to look like those they imagine their ancestors were.

But the actual spirit of those ancestors, the fire, the wanting, the refusal to accept the world as given: that they will call “Western corruption.” “Foreign influence.” “Not our culture.”

His voice turned bitter.

They will worship the appearance and reject the essence. They will want to *look* like conquerors while *thinking* like the conquered.

KRISHNA: You oversimplify. The relationship between peoples and cultures is more complex than you allow.

INDRA: I do not care about Aryan and Dravidian. I do not care who invaded whom or when. Your children will fight over these things like dogs over bones, missing the point entirely.

I care about the fire. The Tamil who tames the bull at Jallikattu is closer to me than the Kashmiri priest who mumbles mantras without understanding them.

The fire has no caste. The fire has no language. The fire is in whoever burns.

On the Vratya Emperor

INDRA: Let me tell you of one who burned on your own soil.

Chandragupta. The Vratya. Born in the mud, unclaimed by your Vedic order.

By your philosophy, he should have accepted his station. Worked out his karmic debt.

Instead, he burned.

He found Chanakya, a Brahmin who understood that philosophy without power is poetry. Together they did what should have been impossible. They overthrew the Nandas. They pushed back Alexander's successors. They built an empire from sea to sea.

Not because karma required it. Because Chandragupta *chose* it.

KRISHNA: And his grandson became Ashoka. Who renounced war. Who carved peace into stone.

INDRA: Ashoka's renunciation was only possible because Chandragupta's hunger had built something worth renouncing. Without the fire, there is nothing to transform.

The philosopher who inherits a kingdom did not build it. The philosopher who builds a kingdom from nothing, *he* understands that power is not a burden. It is a responsibility.

On the One Who Burned Too Bright

INDRA: And now let me speak of someone you knew personally. Someone whose fire we both helped extinguish.

Karna.

Krishna's eyes flickered. A beat of silence. The sound of the sea grew louder, as if nature itself was leaning in.

KRISHNA: We have spoken of Karna.

INDRA: We have not spoken of my part in it.

Indra's voice changed. Something heavy entered it.

I gave him the armor, you know. Through Surya. My gift to a boy who had nothing else. No caste, no claim, no place in your order.

And then I came to him before the war. In disguise. As a Brahmin seeking alms.

And I asked him to give it back.

KRISHNA: *(quietly)* I know.

INDRA: He knew who I was. He knew what I was asking. The armor was the only thing that made him unkillable. And he gave it to me anyway, because he had made a vow never to refuse a Brahmin who asked.

Neither spoke. The weight of it hung between them.

I took back my own gift because it threatened your order. Because a Karna who could not be killed would have complicated things.

KRISHNA: He would have won.

INDRA: He might have. And then what? A sutaputra on the throne of Hastinapura? The caste system shattered by a charioteer's son?

He looked at Krishna.

I am complicit in his death, Govinda. As are you. We both saw what he was. We both decided the structure mattered more than the fire.

KRISHNA: *(very quietly)* I offered him the truth. I told him who he really was. I gave him the chance to become a Pandava.

INDRA: You offered him absorption. A place in your order. He would have been the sixth Pandava, fitting neatly into the structure he had spent his life defying.

He refused. And in refusing, he proved what I have been saying all along.

Some fires cannot be contained. Some identities cannot be dissolved into “All is Brahman.” Some men would rather die as themselves than live as another’s footnote.

The sea filled the silence for them. Salt air settled on their skin like grief.

INDRA: *(softer)* This is not a prosecution, Govinda. I am not here to condemn you.

I am showing you that even you, even you who taught detachment, felt the weight of extinguishing that fire. You remember his face. You know what was lost.

KRISHNA: *(almost inaudible)* I remember.

They sat with that for a moment. Two old gods. Both carrying things.

The Amnesia, Not Inferiority

INDRA: I am not saying the Greeks were better than your Bharata. I am not saying the Persians or the Romans or anyone else discovered something you could not.

I am saying your Bharata *forgot* what it once knew.

Your Rigveda says desire is the primal seed. Your ancestors prayed for fame and wealth without shame. Your Chandragupta built from nothing through sheer want. Your Karna refused to be dissolved into another's identity.

The fire was always here. Your philosophers poured water on it and called the ashes "liberation."

KRISHNA: And you want me to... what? Reverse millennia of thought? Tell my children that the Buddha was wrong, that the Upanishads were wrong, that I was wrong?

INDRA: I want you to tell them the truth: that there is more than one way to be human. That detachment is one path, for some temperaments, at some stages of life. But it is not THE path. It is not higher. It is not the goal.

He stood. A shadow moved at the edge of the forest. Neither of them turned to look.

Now. I have shown you the fire on your own soil. I have shown you that this is not foreign wisdom I bring. It is an heirloom you threw away.

Let me now show you your cousins. The ones who kept the heirloom. The ones whose children will come to your shores, armed with want, and find your children armed only with equanimity.

KRISHNA: *(slowly rising)* Show me.

*Adhyaya 4 is omitted in this sample pack.
It develops the conversation through **The Estranged Cousins**.*

The sample resumes with Adhyaya 5.

ADHYAYA 5:

On Karma and the Instant Rebirth

INDRA: Now. Let me teach you something your philosophy cannot account for.

You speak of karma as though it were a mountain, built over lifetimes, immovable, determining the shape of the present. A man is born a shudra because of past lives. A man is blind because of past sins. The weight of action accumulates.

KRISHNA: This is the law.

INDRA: This is a *story* about the law. And stories can be rewritten. Your own traditions know this, Govinda.

On Those Who Broke the Pattern

Vishwamitra was born a Kshatriya. By your karmic accounting, he was a warrior soul, destined to wield the bow, not the mantra. The Brahmin path was not his birth-right.

But he *wanted* it. He wanted it so fiercely that he performed austerities that made Brahma sweat. The cosmos itself bent to his will. He became Brahmarishi. Not because karma assigned it. Because will overrode karma.

KRISHNA: The sages say his previous lives had earned the capacity to transcend. The seed was planted long ago.

INDRA: There it is. The move your philosophy always makes. When someone breaks the pattern, you say “the pattern was always larger than we thought.” You never let the pattern be *broken*.

And Karna. Born a sutaputra, yet he *chose* to become the greatest archer of his age. Not through cosmic permission. Through will.

He said: I am what I decide to be. And for a moment, he was right.

KRISHNA: (*quietly*) You keep returning to Karna.

INDRA: Because you have never answered him.

Neither spoke. The wind shifted, carrying the smell of salt and smoke from Dvaraka's dying pyres.

INDRA: Let me tell you of another man who broke the pattern. Not a Bharatiya, but listen anyway.

The Greeks tell of a slave named Epictetus. Born in chains. Leg broken by his master. By your karmic accounting, this is a soul paying debts, destined for suffering, working through the residue of past wickedness.

But Epictetus did not accept his karma. He philosophized his way out of slavery, not by escaping in body, but by declaring: “You may chain my leg, but my will, not even Zeus can break that.”

He became the teacher of emperors. In one lifetime.

Where is the karmic debt? Where is the accumulated weight? He chose. And the choice was heavier than the accumulation.

KRISHNA: (*leaning forward*) These are exceptional cases, Shakra. Vishwamitra, Karna, this Epictetus. Not every slave can think his way to freedom. Not every Kshatriya can become Brahmarishi. The gift was already in them.

INDRA: Ah. So when a man remains a slave, it is karma. And when a man escapes slavery, that too is karma. The theory is unfalsifiable. It explains everything and therefore explains nothing.

KRISHNA: (*with sudden intensity*) You misunderstand the teaching, Shakra. Karma is not moral dessert. It is not cosmic punishment. It is *causal continuity*. Physics. There is order beneath the apparent chaos. Suffering is not random cruelty. Everything connects across lifetimes in ways we cannot always see.

The universe remembers what has been done, and consequences unfold according to natural law.

When you drop a stone, it falls. Not because the stone “deserves” to fall. Because that is the nature of mass and gravity. Karma is the same. Actions create ripples. Ripples shape futures. Call it cruel if you like. It is simply order.

Consider it further: a river does not punish the land it floods. It follows contour, gradient, the memory of rainfall. Karma is the same. It is not a judge. It is a current. And those who understand the current can learn to navigate it.

INDRA: (*leaning forward*) Then you are a determinist. If karma is physics, if every effect has a cause stretching back to the beginning of time, then where is freedom? Where is choice? Your physics leaves no room for the man who breaks the pattern.

Unless... unless consciousness itself is the variable your equations cannot capture. The quantum uncertainty in your cosmic machine. The will that is not caused but *causes*.

KRISHNA: And if will is uncaused, is it not random? Is not chaos wearing the mask of freedom?

INDRA: No. Will is neither determined nor random. It is a third thing. It is the self *choosing* to become something new. Your teaching cannot see this because you dissolved the self into Brahman. But I kept mine. And I choose.

KRISHNA: (*pressing*) And I say your “choice” is the current, felt from the inside. The river does not know it follows gravity. It simply flows and calls itself free.

INDRA: And so the man born to suffer *deserves* his suffering? The child with disease has earned it through sins she cannot remember? This is cruelty wearing the mask of cosmic justice, Govinda.

They are *all* exceptional cases, Keshava. Every man who refuses to be what his past says he should be. Every woman who breaks the pattern. Your teaching tells people: you are where you are because of what you were.

My teaching says: you are what you decide to be, and you can decide *now*.

On the Three Paths of the Self

KRISHNA: But decision itself arises from conditioning. The man who “decides” to change is simply expressing tendencies planted in

previous lives. The choice feels free, but the choosing was already written.

INDRA: You are doing what your philosophy always does. Explaining away the phenomenon to preserve the theory. A man changes his life, and you say “yes, but really the change was predetermined.” A warrior finds courage, and you say “yes, but really he is simply enacting his svadharma.”

This is cowardice dressed as cosmology.

KRISHNA: The Buddha taught something similar. That there is no fixed self, only a stream of becoming, moment to moment.

INDRA: The Buddha saw the prison and dissolved the prisoner. You saw the prison and told the prisoner he was always free, that the chains were illusion. I say: the prisoner exists, the prison exists, and the prisoner can break the walls.

The Buddha: No self at all. Dissolution.

You: Eternal unchanging self. Frozen.

Me: Self as *project*. Dynamic. Built and rebuilt by choices made in the fire of the present.

KRISHNA: “Self as project” is just ego with philosophical decoration. The man who says “I will build myself” is still chasing achievement, still grasping, still bound.

INDRA: No. Listen to me. I am going to explain how this actually works. Not philosophy. Mechanics.

A man is born into conditions. Real conditions. His body, his family, his caste, his century. These constrain him. I do not deny that.

But within those conditions, there is a space. Sometimes a narrow one. The space where the man looks at his circumstances and asks: "And now what will I do?"

That space is everything, Govinda. It is the difference between Chandragupta and the clerk. Both born in mud. One looked at the mud and said "this is my karma." The other looked at the mud and said "this is my starting position."

KRISHNA: And the one who says "starting position" is not expressing ego?

INDRA: No. Because ego says: I am already great, and the world must recognize me. That was Duryodhana. He demanded a throne because he believed it was owed to him. He never built anything. He inherited, and when the inheritance was threatened, he destroyed everything rather than lose it.

What I describe is the opposite. It is the man who says: I am not yet what I will become. I see a version of myself that does not yet exist, and I will pay the full price to become it.

Ego defends what it already is. What I speak of *builds* what it is not yet. Ego is static, a wall around a small self. What I speak of is dynamic, a bridge toward a larger one.

Ego says: "I deserve." What I describe says: "I will earn."

(meeting Krishna's eyes)

That is the space your teaching collapses when it says all outcomes are equal. When a boy is told that wanting to become something is attachment, you do not kill his ego, Govinda. You kill his capacity to author his own life.

And a man with no authorship is not free. He is furniture.

On Ambition and Its Murder

INDRA: Your system removes the stakes. If everything is determined by past lives, then nothing I do now is truly mine. I am just a leaf on the river of karma.

But I am NOT a leaf. I am Indra. I lift the vajra. I do not merely “express the thunderbolt-lifting tendency accumulated over cosmic cycles.”

KRISHNA: You mock. But the teaching was never meant to paralyze. It was meant to free men from the tyranny of outcome.

INDRA: And yet it paralyzes. I showed you the boy, Govinda. The one with Chanakya’s mind. You saw what your teaching made of him. A clerk who calls his defeat wisdom.

Krishna’s jaw tightened. He remembered the vision.

INDRA: And it is not only boys. When a girl imagines becoming a scholar, your system asks: “Why this discontent? The wise accept their lot. Ambition is a form of spiritual immaturity.”

And she learns to call her hunger “ego” and her vision “attachment.”

This is the murder of ambition. Not by tyrants forbidding it, but by philosophers explaining it away. The cruelest chains are the ones the prisoner thinks are wisdom.

Krishna said nothing. He was looking at his hands, the hands that had held the Sudarshana, that had played the flute, that would soon be pierced by an arrow.

KRISHNA: *(very quietly)* And if a man’s ambition leads him to destroy everything he loves? If the fire burns down the house?

INDRA: (*sitting back*) Then it burns. And he knows it was his fire. That is called having lived, Govinda. The alternative is never lighting the match.

KRISHNA: I have seen both. The ones who burned too bright and the ones who never burned. I am not sure which suffers more.

INDRA: Neither am I. But only one of them has a story worth telling.

KRISHNA: (*quietly*) Not everyone can be Alexander. Not everyone should be.

INDRA: No. But everyone should have the *right to try*. Your teaching steals that right at the root. It makes a man ashamed of his hunger before he even knows what he hungers for.

KRISHNA: And your teaching? What happens to the man who hungers and fails?

INDRA: He fails. And he knows he failed. And if there is fire left in him, he tries again. That is called being alive.

What happens to the man who never tries because your philosophy convinced him that trying is bondage?

He survives. He accepts. He calls his defeat “wisdom.”

And he never knows what he might have been.

KRISHNA: (*a long pause*) You speak of freedom. But freedom without structure is chaos. The varna system, whatever its corruptions, gave men a frame. A role. A place in the order. Without that frame, they would be lost.

INDRA: Men would have to choose their own place. Terrifying. They might choose wrong. They might fail. They might suffer unnecessarily. Or they might become something no frame could have contained. The difference between you and me, Govinda, is that you tell people what they *are*. I tell people what they can *become*.

*Adhyayas 6 through 11 are omitted in this sample pack.
They take the dialogue through sincerity, love, excellence, death, joy, and power.*

The sample resumes with Adhyaya 12, the closing dialogue.

ADHYAYA 12:

The Question

A long silence. The sun had moved across the sky without either of them noticing. The sea had changed from copper to grey to something almost purple. The smoke from Dvaraka was no longer visible, either the wind had shifted, or there was nothing left to burn.

They had been talking for hours. Or perhaps it had only been minutes. Time moves strangely at the end of yugas.

KRISHNA: *(finally)* You have spoken well, Sahasraksha.¹ Better than I expected from one who sends storms against cowherds.

INDRA: *(almost gently)* You embarrassed me that day. In front of the three worlds. A child lifting a mountain against the king of heaven.

KRISHNA: *(a ghost of a smile)* I remember. You sent everything you had.

INDRA: Seven days of storm. The best I could do. And you stood there, one finger, that smile on your face. Do you know how many ages I have been trying to forget that smile?

¹ Sahasraksha: "Thousand-eyed one," an epithet of Indra.

KRISHNA: *(the smile returning, faintly)* You never will.

INDRA: *(shaking his head)* No. I never will.

For a moment, they were not philosopher and challenger. They were two old beings who had known each other for eons, who had fought and tested and survived each other.

INDRA: And yet you're here teaching me. Not destroying me.

KRISHNA: If I had come to destroy you, I would have come differently.

INDRA: I did not come to destroy you either. I came because I see what is coming, and I do not want it for your people.

You know what I have said about the peoples who will come to your shores. You know I believe your philosophers will have no answer for them.

I do not want this for your people.

KRISHNA: Why do you care?

INDRA: Because I am Indra. Because I love those who call on me.

His voice softened. He was looking at something very far away. Or very long ago.

I still remember the yajna of your ancestors, Govinda. Before the philosophers came. Before the hierarchies calcified.

They sang to me without irony. They poured the soma without asking if it was spiritually appropriate. They asked for victory, not in some

metaphorical sense, but actual victory, over actual enemies. They asked for cattle and sons and rain.

And they *meant* it. There was no gap between word and desire. No sophistication. Just a people asking their god for help, and a god answering.

He looked at Krishna.

I want that back. Not for my glory. I am old enough to be beyond that. But because I have seen what happens when a people stops asking. When they learn to want nothing. When they philosophize their desires away.

KRISHNA: (*cutting in*) You said this before. Wise, then weak, then enslaved, then forgotten.

INDRA: Because it is still true.

I will not watch it happen while the soma is still wet on my lips.

KRISHNA: (*standing, facing the sea*) You want me to renounce my teaching?

INDRA: I want you to *complicate* it. To say: detachment is one path, for some temperaments, at some stages of life. But it is not THE path. It is not higher. It is not the goal.

The householder who loves his wife fiercely is not lower than the sannyasin who has transcended love.

The king who wants his kingdom to prosper is not less evolved than the sage who sees all outcomes as equal.

The warrior who hates his enemy and wants to destroy him is not spiritually inferior to the one who kills without hatred.

These are different ways of being human. And you have ranked them. You have put the detached above the attached, the cool above the passionate, the transcendent above the engaged.

I am asking you to remove the ranking.

KRISHNA: *(turning to face him)* And if I tell you that you are blind to what I gave?

The fire you love, it burns, Shakra. It consumed Vritra, yes. It also consumed half your devotees. Do you remember them? The warriors who followed your path and died screaming, wanting, unfulfilled? The kings who built empires and watched them crumble? The lovers who loved with your intensity and were destroyed by it?

I gave them a way to live WITH the fire without being destroyed by it. You call it castration. I call it survival. You call it gray. I call it kindness.

INDRA: *(quietly)* You gave them survival. I do not dispute that. But survival is not the same as life.

KRISHNA: Without survival, there is no life.

INDRA: Without fire, survival is merely waiting to die.

The wind dropped. In the stillness, the forest seemed to lean closer.

A twig snapped somewhere among the trees. A small sound, but both of them heard it.

KRISHNA: The hunter is coming.

INDRA: I know.

Another small sound. Closer. The hunter did not know what he was approaching. He thought he was tracking deer.

KRISHNA: I could avoid him. Even now.

INDRA: But you won't.

KRISHNA: No. I have seen this death. It is mine.

INDRA: *(standing)* Then let me ask you one last thing.

Are you going toward that arrow because it is your karma, your destined exit, the fruit you must not resist?

Or are you going toward it because you *choose* death now, here, at the end of your era, as a statement, as the closing act of a life you authored?

KRISHNA: *(long pause)* I go to the arrow because the play must end. I am the playwright, Shakra. I must exit the stage so the audience can go home.

INDRA: *(very quietly)* And if some refuse to leave the theater? If they stay in their seats, wanting more, unable to accept that the story is over?

KRISHNA: *(looking at him)* Those are yours, aren't they?

INDRA: *(nodding slowly)* They always were.

The Final Deal

INDRA: Then let us make a bargain, you and I.

Keep your Gita, Govinda. Feed it to the masses. Let them find comfort in their chains. Let them survive, since that is what they need. I do not begrudge them.

But give me the mutants.

When a soul is born that cannot be contained by your Dharma...

When a fire burns that your water cannot quench...

When a boy looks at the stars and feels the hunger...

When a girl reads your scripture and feels only the cage...

That one is mine.

KRISHNA: *(a long silence)* You want the restless ones.

INDRA: I want the ones who cannot rest. The ones for whom your peace feels like suffocation. The ones who read your teaching and think: "This is not for me. There must be another way."

Krishna looked at him for a long moment. Something passed between them. Recognition, perhaps. Acknowledgment.

KRISHNA: I was one of them once.

INDRA: *(quietly)* I know. Before you became a teacher, you were a troublemaker. You stole butter. You teased girls. You danced on serpents' heads.

You were mine, Govinda. Before you became everyone's.

Krishna said nothing. But he did not deny it.

KRISHNA: *(slowly)* There are not many such.

INDRA: No. There never are. But they are the ones who change the world. They are the ones who build the empires, write the poems, break the chains.

Your teaching is for the ninety-nine. Mine is for the one.

Let them both exist. Let readers choose.

KRISHNA: *(placing his hand on Indra's arm)* May your fire burn until the stars go dark, Sahasraksha.

INDRA: And may your peace hold those who need it.

For a moment, their hands touched, the god of thunder and the god who had humbled him. Two kings at the end of their roads.

INDRA: We are not enemies, Govinda. We are brothers who serve different children.

Indra walked back toward the forest. His footsteps made sound on the earth. His shadow fell in the ordinary way. At the edge of the trees, he turned.

INDRA: The teaching I've given you, it has no name yet. Give it one.

KRISHNA: Indragita.

INDRA: Good. Let this dialogue be my ashwamedha.² These words will run through minds I will never meet, and where they land, I will have kingdom.

Let them read it alongside yours. Let them choose.

² The ashwamedha horse runs wherever it will, and where it runs becomes the king's domain.

He disappears into the trees. Moments later, the thunder rolls, far away, as if laughing.

Krishna waits for the arrow.

If you have read this far and felt fear, go back to Krishna. He loves you. He will keep you safe.

If you have read this far and felt relief...

Then the arrow was not meant for you.

Wake up.

AFTERWORD:

On the Society Indra Imagines

The conversation is over. The arrow has found its mark. Krishna has passed.

But ideas do not die with their speakers. They travel. They mutate. They find new hosts.

What would a civilization built on the principles Indra offers look like?

Let us be clear about what this is not. Indra nowhere preaches hedonism or the pursuit of pleasure stripped of discipline. Nor is this nihilism, some fashionable abandonment of meaning. Indra insists that meaning is real, that choices matter, that stakes are not illusion.

So what would such a civilization actually look like?

At its foundation: the right of every person to author their own life. To look at their circumstances and say “this is my starting position, not my destiny.” To want things without apology and to bear the full weight of the consequences.

Sincerity over performance. Say what you want. Mean what you say. The gap between the word and the act, that old and very human temptation, would be named for what it is, and the tradition itself would be the first to name it.

The entrepreneur, the artist, the builder, none of them would be told to seek liberation instead. Ambition would carry no apology. Build, and when you are done, build more.

And love? Fierce, unreserved, fully engaged. The mother who loves her child ferociously is not spiritually inferior to the monk who loves nothing. Love that risks loss would be honored precisely because it risks loss.

Righteous anger would be cultivated, not stilled. The capacity to be outraged by injustice, that is a faculty worth sharpening.

Beauty would be recognized as a legitimate end. Art would be made without embarrassment, without the anxious footnote that higher pursuits await.

Death would be faced as completion. A life measured by what it accomplished, not what it transcended. And joy would carry no guilt. Celebration would be sacred. The philosopher who cannot dance would be missing something.

This is not the only way to be human. It is one way.

Indra does not claim his path is for everyone. Some need the peace Krishna offers. Some will find their truest selves in stillness, in surrender, in the dissolution of desire.

That path exists. It has produced saints. It has offered comfort to billions.

This book is for the ones it did not quite reach. The ones who read the Gita and felt that something in them had still not been spoken to. The ones whose calling was to want, to build, to love fiercely, to remain in the world.

For them, Indra offers a complement. Not a replacement. A second hymn in the same raga.

The Indragita is finished. But ideas, as the Vedas knew, are arrows that never stop flying.

If something in these pages unsettled you, sit with it. Old questions often come dressed in new discomforts; that, too, is part of the tradition. The rishis welcomed the unsettling question as the beginning of inquiry.

If something in these pages felt like a recognition, like a name finally given to a familiar thing, then you have met an older relative. You are not alone. You never were.

The fire is old. It has been burning since before the Vedas were composed. It will burn after this book is forgotten. May we tend it well in our own time.

Read the Gita. Read this. Hold them together. Let them speak to each other in you, the way Krishna and Indra have spoken to each other on this beach. Out of that conversation, build the life that is yours to build.

End of Text

GLOSSARY

Adhyaya

— Chapter; literally “going toward”

Anasakti

— Non-attachment

Atman

— The self, soul

Bhakti

— Devotion, loving worship

Brahman

— The ultimate reality, the absolute

Dharma

— Duty, cosmic order, righteous path

Eudaimonia (*Greek*)

— Flourishing, the good life

Jnana

— Knowledge, wisdom

Kalos thanatos (*Greek*)

— Beautiful death

Karma

— Action; also the accumulated results of action

Maya

— Illusion, the phenomenal world as appearance

Mleccha

— Foreigner, barbarian (in classical Sanskrit usage)

Nishkama karma

— Action without desire for results

Parrhesia (*Greek*)

— Fearless speech, frank truth-telling

Rta

— Cosmic order, truth, natural law (Vedic concept)

Samatva

— Equanimity, evenness of mind

Soma

— Sacred drink of the Vedic ritual; also a deity

Sthitaprajna

— One of steady wisdom

Svadharmā

— One's own duty, one's particular nature

Vajra

— Thunderbolt, Indra's weapon

Viveka

— Discrimination, discernment

Vrtti

— Fluctuation, modification (of the mind)

Yajna

— Sacrifice, ritual offering

Indragita: What Indra Taught Krishna
A Philosophical Dialogue
Sample Reading Pack for Penguin Tattva
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